Angels in America: Millennium Approaches

By Tony Kushner

HARPER: People who are lonely, people left alone, sit talking nonsense to the air, imagining . . . beautiful systems dying, old fixed orders spiraling apart . . .

When you look at the ozone layer, from outside, from a spaceship it looks like a pale blue halo, a gentle, shimmering aureole encircling the atmosphere encircling the earth. Thirty miles above our heads, a thin layer of three-atom oxygen molecules, product of photosynthesis, which explains the fussy vegetable preference for visible light, its rejection of darker rays and emanations. Danger from without.

It's a kind of gift, from God, the crowning touch to the creation of the world: guardian angels, hands linked, make a spherical net, a blue-green nesting orb, a shell of safety for life itself. But everywhere, thing are collapsing, lies surfacing, systems of defense giving way . . . This is why, Joe, this is why I shouldn't be left alone. (Little pause)

I'd like to go travelling . . . Leave you behind to worry. I'll send postcards with strange stamps and tantalizing messages on the back. 'Later maybe.' 'Nevermore . . .'

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INTRODUCTION

Harper is a mess. A quirky, loveable mess, but a mess all the same. Agoraphobic (afraid of public places) and hooked on valium, Harper spends most of her time hallucinating in her Brooklyn apartment while her husband, Joe, is away from home. Joe is a straight-laced Mormon from Salt Lake City adrift in big city of New York. Raised to think that homosexuality is a sin, he takes a giant step away from the morality he grew up with.

A society that encourages the repression of homosexuality isn't just harmful to gay people themselves. If Joe had felt comfortable with his sexuality, he never would have married Harper, and she wouldn't have suffered years of torture. Maybe they would have just been good friends – who knows? Instead, societal pressure forced them into a life of denial. In this scene the walls of denial finally crumble. Angels in America: Millennium Approaches by Tony Kushner.

HARPER: Where were you?

JOE: Out.

HARPER: Where?

JOE: Just out. Thinking.

HARPER: It's late.

JOE: I had a lot to think about.

HARPER: I burned dinner.

JOE: Sorry.

HARPER: Not my dinner. My dinner was fine. Your dinner. I put it back in the oven and turned everything up as high as it could go and I watched till it burned black. It's still hot. Very hot. Want it?

JOE: You didn't have to do that.

HARPER: I know. It just seemed like the kind of thing a mentally deranged sex-starved pill-popping housewife would do.

JOE: Uh huh

HARPER: So I did it. Who know anymore what I have to do?

JOE: How many pills?

HARPER: A bunch. Don't change the subject.

JOE: I won't talk to you when you . . .

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HARPER: No. No. Don't do that! I'm . . . I'm fine pills are not the problem, not our problem. I WANT TO KNOW WHERE YOU'VE BEEN! I WANT TO KNOW WHAT'S GOING ON!

JOE: Going on with what? The job?

HARPER: Not the job.

JOE: I said I need more time.

HARPER: Not the job!

JOE: Mr. Cohn, I talked to him on the phone, he said I had to hurry . . .

HARPER: Not the . . .

JOE: But I can't get you to talk sensibly about anything so

HARPER: SHUT UP!

JOE: Then what?

HARPER: Stick to the subject.

JOE: I don't know what that is. You have something you want to ask me? Ask me. Go

HARPER: I . . . . can't. I'm scared of you.

JOE: I'm tired. I'm going to bed.

HARPER: Tell me without making me ask. Please.

JOE: This is crazy, I'm not . . .

HARPER: When you come through the door at night your face is never exactly the way I remembered it. I get surprised by something . . . mean and hard about the way you look. Even the weight of you in the bed at night, the way you breathe in your sleep seems unfamiliar. (Beat) You terrify me.

JOE: I know who you are.

HARPER: Yes. I'm the enemy. That's easy. That doesn't change. You think you're the only one who hates sex; I do; I hate it with you; I do. I dream that you batter away at me till all my joints come apart, like wax, and I fall into pieces. It's like

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a punishment. It was wrong of me to marry you. I knew you . . . (She stops herself) It's a sin, and it's killing us both.

JOE: I can always tell when you've taken pills because it makes you red-faced and sweaty and frankly that's very often why I don't want to . . .

HARPER: Because . . .

JOE: Well, you aren't pretty. Not like this.

HARPER: I have something to ask you.

JOE: Then ASK! AKS! What in the hell are you . . .

HARPER: Are you a homo? (Beat) Are you? IF you try to walk out right now I'll put your dinner back in the oven and turn it up so high the whole building will fill with smoke and everyone will asphyxiate. SO help me God I will. Now answer the question.

JOE: What if I . . . (Beat)

HARPER: Then tell me, please. And we'll see.

JOE: No. I'm not. I don't see what difference it makes. (Beat) I think we ought to pray. Ask God for help. Ask him together . . .

HARPER: God won't talk to me. I have to make up people to talk to me.

JOE: You have to keep asking.

HARPER: I forgot the question. Oh year. God, is my husband a . . .

JOE: Stop it. Stop it. I'm warning you. Does that make any difference? That I might be one thing deep within, no matter how wrong or ugly that thing is, so long as I have fought, with everything I have, to kill it. What do you want from me? What do you want from me, Harper? More than that? For God's sake, there's nothing left, I'm a shell. There's nothing left to kill. (Beat) As long as my behavior is what I know it has to be. Decent. Correct. That alone in the eyes of God.

HARPER: No, no not that, that's Utah talk, Mormon talk. I hate it, Joe, tell me, say it . . .

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JOE: All I will say is that I am a very good man who has worked very hard to become good and you want to destroy that. You want to destroy me, but I am not going to let you do that. (Beat).

HARPER: I'm going to have a baby.

JOE: Liar.

HARPER: You liar. A baby born addicted to pills. A baby who does not dream but who hallucinates, who stares up as us with big mirror eyes and who does not know who we are. (Beat)

JOE: Are you really . . ..

HARPER: No. Yes. No. Yes. Get away from me. Now we both have a secret. (Beat) When you pray, what do you pray for?

JOE: I pray for God to crush me, break me up into little pieces and start all over again.

HARPER: Oh. Please. Don't pray for that.

JOE: I had a book of Bible stories when I was a kid. There was a picture I'd look at twenty times every day: Jacob wrestles with the angel. I don't really remember the story, or why the wrestling – just the picture. Jacob is young and very strong. The angel is . . . a beautiful man, with golden hair and wings, of course. I still dram about it. Many night. I'm . . . It's me. In that struggle. Fierce, and unfair. The angel is not human, and it holds nothing back, so how could anyone human win, what kind of a fight is that? It's no just. Losing means your soul torn down in the dust, your heart torn out from God's. But you can't not lose.

HARPER: In the whole entire world, you are the only person, the only person I love or have ever loved. And I love you terribly. Terribly. That's what's so awfully, irreducibly real. I can make up anything but I can't dream that way.

JOE: Are you . . . are you really going to have a baby?

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HARPER: It's my time, and there's no blood. I don't really know. I suppose it wouldn't be a great thing. Maybe I'm just not bleeding because I take too many pills. Maybe I'll give birth to a pill. That would give a new meaning to pill popping, huh? I think you should go to Washington. Alone.

JOE: I'm not going to leave you, Harper.

HARPER: Well maybe not, But I'm going to leave you.

JOE: Harper. Please listen. I still love you very much. You're still my best buddy; I'm not going to leave you. Please listen. Stay. This is really hard. We have to talk.

HARPER: We are talking. Aren't we. Now please shut up. OK?

JOE: Just listen. You want the truth. This is the truth. I knew this when I married you. I've know this I guess for as long as I've known anything, but . . . I don't know, I thought maybe that with enough effort and will I could change myself . . . but I can't . . . I'm losing ground here, I go walking, you want to know where I walk, I . . . go to the park or up and down 53rd Street, or places where . . . And I keep swearing I won't go walking again, but I just can't. (Beat) I try to tighten my heart into a knot, a snarl, I try to learn to live dead, just numb, but then I see someone I want, and it's like a nail, like a hot spike right through my chest, and I know I'm losing. My whole life has conspired to bring me to this place, and I can't despise my whole life. I think I believed when I met you I could save you, you at least if not myself, but . . . I don't have any sexual feeling for you, Harper. And I don't think I ever did. (Little pause)

HARPER: I think you should go.

JOE: Where?

HARPER: Washington. Doesn't matter.

JOE: What are you talking about?

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HARPER: Without me. Without me, Joe. Isn't that what you want to hear? (little pause)

JOE: Yes.

HARPER: You were going to save me, but the whole time you were spinning a lie. I just don't understand that. . . This is so scary, I want this to stop, to go back . . .

JOE: Harper . . . As long as I've known you Harper you've been afraid of . . . of men hiding under the bed, men hiding under the sofa, men with knives. Who are these men? I never understood it. Now I know.

HARPER: What?

JOE: It's me. . . . I'm the man with the knives.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Tony Kushner
ISBN: 978-1559360616
Publisher: Theatre Communications Group
Date (Month/Year): April 1993

AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
Utah State Finalist